

Q&A Concerning States of Mind - Saṅkhāra (Geneva May 2006)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · International Talks · 1:04:11

There are one or two questions here, but if there are other questions that might arise afterwards, we can, let's say, entertain ourselves with them.

How can one create karmic formations? *Saṅkhāra*. Yes, karmic formations. And after that? What can we experience? What do we call it? *Bhavanga*. That is to say, the flux?

Well, let me answer the second question, *bhavanga*. *Bhavanga* means... The *bhavanga* means the factor of becoming, the link. Yes, the link.

This is in relation to the Abhidhamma, which is the last part of the Buddha's teaching. No, after the Buddha. It came about because there was great interest in trying to describe what consciousness was. What it consisted of, how long it lasted.

So now, in a moment of consciousness, there are seventeen parts. I don't remember the seventeen parts. But I can give you the framework.

When we hear something, the first thing we perceive is a noise. Knocking, yes. Let's say it's a kind of drumbeat. A beating. This you can experience in your meditation. It's not something the Venerable is making up.

When a wave, let's say, of sound comes and you feel it like a touch, at that moment consciousness is awakened by contact, the beating. When contact is established, what is it called? It comes into the mind? It comes into the mind? It is caught in the mind? It is absorbed by the mind? It's as if someone knocks at your door and you invite them in.

The next thing you perceive is the sound of a bell. There, after comes the word, the perception, let's say, of the sound of the bell. At that moment comes, let's say, the meaning, the sound equals, let's say, awakening or the bell. The bell, the awakening.

After, you have, let's say, well after the meaning "wake up." After, well, let's say, "I must get up." And then after, it stops there. The next thought is to get up.

Now, between the two intervals of the two thoughts, the mind stops. In the seventeen parts of the moment of consciousness, there is one. Three that are, let's say, at the beginning and three, let's say, at the end.

At that moment, at that interval, the mind stops, the mind, let's say, rests. What they call these three moments is the link, let's say, of consciousness. That is the *bhavanga*. Sleep, let's say, is *bhavanga*. Deep sleep.

Let's say, at that moment, let's say, there is nothing, but the mind is still there. So if there is no consciousness, at that moment, you would not hear the sound of the alarm, of the bell. Yes?

The question is can we experience *bhavanga*? We cannot do it objectively. In normal sleep. But in very good meditation, if your meditation is very good, you can find yourself in sleep. In meditation that is very refined, you can find yourself awake in sleep.

And you can experience the mind as a flow of energy, there is nothing in it. You will be conscious, you will know that you are asleep. There are no words. There are no words. Because the mind, the body, is immobile, but you are awake.

In the same way that many other people experience... What do they call that? When you wake up in a dream. Lucid dreaming, thank you very much. Yes, so you are there, you see the dream, you hear it.

But generally, we do not experience *bhavanga* as an object. But let's say, in general, we do not experience *bhavanga* as a mental object.

How not to create karmic formations, *sankhāra*? To understand this, we would have to return to the explanation of the five aggregates, the pieces, the five pieces. We call them *khandhā*. *Khandhā*. Or for the Tibetans, *skandha*. Yes, for the Tibetans, *skandha*. You have seen that? *Skandha*. Ah, alright.

So the first *khandhā*, the first piece, are all these things that have to do with what we call the body. Our physical nature. The first aggregate is called the body, the physical body. For those of you who know all this, this really refers to the four great elements.

The quality of heat. The quality of fire. The quality, let's say, of what is light and what is heavy, that is to say of gravity. What we call the earth element. The quality of movement. What we call the air element. The wind, yes. The wind or air? The quality of what is cohesive, let's say what sticks, like chewing gum. Cohesion, yes. That is water. That is water? That is water, yes.

No, yes, no, chewing gum is an example. No, chewing gum is an example. The Buddha, I don't think there was chewing gum. Well, I think at the time of the Buddha, there was not yet chewing gum.

So this is what we call *rūpa*, the body, physicality. The next is entirely related to feeling. These are sensations that come from the body, pleasant and unpleasant. Yes, like pain in the knee or food on your tongue that is pleasant. Like pain in your knee or the taste of food on your tongue, it is agreeable.

And this also refers to the sensation of your emotional life, agreeable or disagreeable. And all the sensations that come from the body and that are neutral. All of that constitutes *vedanā*. All of that, these

are the sensations, let's say, that come from the body. Is there another word, another word for "feeling"? Another word? Sensation. No, no, no, perception. Sensation. OK.

The next aggregate are our perceptions. Let's say first, there are the basic perceptions which are the perceptions of colours and forms. *Saññā*, it is called *saññā*.

The fourth aggregate is *sankhāra* that we are going to discuss. The fifth aggregate is consciousness. Each time there is an object, consciousness appears at the same time. It is an act of recognition, of knowing.

All the other sections appear whether we like it or not. Yes, as long as you have a body, there will be feelings, perceptions and consciousness. As long as you have a body, you have sensations, perceptions and consciousness.

These are the elements that constitute *sankhāra*. *Sankhāra* is in addition. We take all these elements and after we go, let's say, to develop... These are mental states and the way we create the world. That is *sankhāra*.

When we enter this room, this hall, immediately there is the perception, let's say, and the sensation we have of the hall. And then, after, we begin to have ideas. Those are our *sankhāras*. The *sankhāras* are what we create. It is something that we create. It is something that we create.

And this fact of creation is first a conscious act. Yes, it is a conscious, voluntary act. It is a voluntary, intentional act.

For example, when we were learning to ride a bicycle, when we begin to learn, let's say, to ride a bicycle, we must practice consciously and deliberately until the moment when we can ride a bicycle. After that, it becomes automatic.

So there is a moment in our life when we tell ourselves how we are angry, let's say, or depressed, or create acts that are not at all effective. And that we also decide, let's say, to be... to have universal love, let's say compassion, friendly feelings and all these decisions become, let's say, our habits and these habits are so buried in ourselves that we are no longer conscious.

And we ask the question why many people do not want to understand us. And after, we are surprised why many people, let's say, offer us services. Most of the time, we are not conscious of our character traits.

Part of the meditation is to make ourselves become much more aware as to what are our driving motivations which are subliminal. Let's say, a part of meditation is to discover what makes us, how do you say, advance and which is subliminal. Subliminal, yes. Freud understands this very well.

Sometimes, in your life, you discover that, let's say, there are certain things that you do not want, that there is resistance on your part to accomplish these things. We... We perceive immediately the resistance, we accept, let's say, not to do it, and we go away. We are not going to, let's say, question this resistance. We

assume that this resistance is normal and correct.

For example, when I do my Mahāsi retreats, we arrive in the morning at 3:30, 4:00. Many people say it's impossible. I cannot do that. If they were taking a plane to Malaga, oh, they arrive at 2:00 in the morning. But if they have to take a plane to go to Malaga at two o'clock in the morning, they will wake up. But for a meditative retreat, for them, it's too early.

And when they... When the Venerable asks why there is this resistance, they already have a ready-made phrase in their minds. Let's say, this phrase originates from, let's say, their childhood. They need eight hours of sleep. Eight hours! A third of their life, let's say, sleeping, that is to say being, how do you say? Dead. Dead. Partly dead.

All these karmic formations are, let's say, made by ourselves. The body is a genetic accident. My eyes can only see what my retina perceives. If I cannot see colours, I cannot see colours. There are basic things I can do nothing about and that, let's say, I find myself with.

The culture in which I find myself, let's say, I did not choose it. You see? There are many zones in my life that are not under my control. When I look at the things I create, my mental states... If I look at what I create, these are my mental states.

And when I go to meditate and I discover with horror that these are mental states, I also cannot control them. And I create a trauma, let's say, in my mind and in my heart. These habits, these mental states, have after a life, let's say, in themselves and they have energy for themselves.

How can I stop these habits that are not effective, that are impure? Those that are pure, I would like to keep them. When the Buddha is awakened, this does not mean that all his mental formations have stopped. It is not that the Buddha, let's say, can no longer think and becomes a block.

It was not as if he could not feel, feel the feelings of other people, feel his own heart. He cannot feel others. When he speaks of himself, he says that what a teacher can do with compassion for his students is what he has done for us. He said that what a teacher...

And the word he uses is not *karuṇā*, the usual word, compassion, he uses the word *anukampā*. Let's say, the word he uses is not *karuṇā*, but... *Anukampā*. *Anukampā*. That means to come towards others, that is to say empathy. Empathy. You see?

So the process of meditation, the process of removing these karmic formations, does not lead us to a kind of death or annihilation. This process of untying these karmic formations is not going towards a cessation, let's say, an immobilism, let's say, a death. It leads us to have a heart full of kindness, compassion, joy, of peace, of joy, of love.

And this process is a process of transformation. What is in us, hatred, let's say... Anger. Anger will be transformed into love. Cruelty to compassion, selfishness to generosity. Cruelty into compassion. How do

you say? Selfishness. Selfishness into kindness. Hmm. It's not generosity, yes.

These *sankhāras*, we have created them but they are based on illusion. Delusion. Delusion. Aversion. Aversion. Greed. Greed, hatred and delusion. Let's say, greed. Yes.

So what we begin, excuse me, what we begin to understand is that once we have set the vehicle in motion, even if you put on the brake, it will still go. Let's say, as soon as we had started the car, even if we want to stop it by hitting the brakes, it continues to roll.

As soon as we have created in us, let's say, anger, depression, all human miseries, all we can do is lift our feet from the accelerator, that is to say stop forgetting them. So put yourself in anger, you have to say no, no, no, but you must let the anger manifest. But we must let, let's say, the anger manifest.

But not let them manifest in words and actions, because, let's say, with this process, we are recreating... But you must allow it to manifest as a sensation. All emotions are a form of energy. Like the weather system. Sometimes it's like this and sometimes it's hot. It's like the weather, sometimes there is wind, sometimes it's hot.

Whatever, let's say, the weather, you have to do what you must do. In you, you always undergo meteorological variations. Sometimes there is an atmospheric depression, let's say, and sometimes there is sun.

Our... let's say... The goal is, let's say, to observe, to be in the position of observer, to experience, to note, but not to be carried away. When we are doing sitting or walking meditation, to maintain this state, let's say, immobile mental state, and to let mental formations appear and let them disappear.

But we cannot make this effort when you cross the street. You cannot stop in the middle of the street and observe anger arise and disappear. In daily life, we know, let's say, mental formations... In daily life, we know there is anger, depression, let's say anxiety. But they stay with us like little dogs. They can, let's say, bark, cry, but they are always there.

But your attention and intention will come from wisdom. If you are at work and suddenly you have, how do you say? Boredom, yes. Boredom is a state, let's say, of hatred. It is an aversion.

So, I am doing my work and I feel bored. Boredom will tell me, go, do something wonderful and distracting. Smoking, shopping, drinking. And then, of course, you lose your job.

So now, instead of being controlled by boredom, we see boredom as just this... Let's say, instead of being controlled by boredom, we must consider it as a big, an annoying dog. It is with us, the annoying dog.

My attention, let's say, will be focused on my work, as well as my intention which comes, let's say, from wisdom. I do my work as a service rendered to others and to myself, let's say, through compassion, through love. Slowly, the old habits will disappear by themselves. The good habits will take hold.

With these *sankhāras*, we see that we can... my mind and my heart I can recreate it so it is something that we must take responsibility for. It is our responsibility. So you cannot from now you cannot say to your colleagues, to your partner, to your spouse, you make me unhappy.

From now on you can no longer say, let's say, that it is the fault, let's say, that comes from your colleagues, from your spouse and that, let's say, they are responsible for your anger. You are the cause of my, let's say, of my problems, let's say, of my, let's say, of my sadness, pity. How fed up!

These karmic formations are our habits. All these habits constitute our personality, our character traits. Once we have a personality and character, this will lead us to our destiny. When we have these character traits, they will lead us towards our destiny.

It is very important to define our character traits and to transform them. Where do we begin? From intention. Intention. This is why, when I insist on this, for people to note intention, the intention to walk. If there is no intention, you do not walk.

So at home, you see, you cannot catch, you cannot catch intention. Perhaps, at home, you don't catch, you are not conscious of intention. And already, when you are conscious of it, you already have another cup of coffee. These are habits.

And when we have, let's say, caught intention, that is to say be conscious of intention, we have power. Let's say there, at the interview of intention, arises, we can ask is it effective, is it not effective, is it pure or is it impure. Then we can say too much coffee, I stop. Or I can say I need coffee to stay awake. You see? You can make a decision.

But once you have empowered an intention, you have lost it, you are late. When we have given power, let's say, to an intention, we have lost control ourselves. The point where we give power, let's say, to an intention, that is a karmic act. It is this act of will that I call an act of *kamma*.

At this point, you condition yourself, you condition. And this is how we create these karmic formations.

Ultimately, all these karmic acts arise from the notion of what we are, which is a delusion. A delusion of what we really are. This is what we call the ego, the self. When we are completely liberated from the self, from the ego, there will still be karmic formations, but as there is no more self, there will be no more attachment.

In the Abhidhamma, there is a distinction between acts that are committed by people who are ignorant and acts that are committed by people who are awakened. There is a new word called *kriya* to explain this difference.

Okay?

I am not so motivated to meditate every day. I am not very motivated to sit every day. I am not happy

because I am not constant. I am not happy because I am not consistent. I find all sorts of excuses not to meditate. Like today. Can you help me to motivate myself and to discipline myself? Let's say, I am afraid, I fear to listen to my inner voice.

Well, when you ask me if I can help you, what you can do is this. Make a very strong determination to meditate for a certain time each day, perhaps half an hour in the morning or an hour in the morning, what you know you can do. First, you must have a very strong resolution to meditate for a certain period every day, half an hour in the morning or an hour in the morning. Each time you don't succeed, you should send 100 francs to the Venerable.

So you should develop your own discipline. You must start small and not ambitiously—even 10 minutes, but you must do it religiously, absolutely religiously, for at least six months. And after that, it becomes a habit, that is to say a *saṅkhāra*. Even if you miss once or twice, your body will push you to do it.

It is much more effective to meditate throughout the day than to meditate only for a long duration in the morning, only in the morning. The morning meditation is to remind you and to give you access to this level of consciousness. And during the day, one minute, two minutes, just to rediscover this level of consciousness. There are many times when you can do this. And you can do it, not only sitting, but walking.

Just think of how many times you walk outside, or you walk from this place to that place, and your mind is everywhere. Do you remember how many times you climb the stairs, the steps, or you go from one place to another, but your mind is everywhere? At that moment, you should refocus on your body and be conscious of what you are doing.

Tomorrow, we are going to do what we didn't do today, which is meditation on universal love. You can also develop this throughout the day. You know, these times when normally we let the mind wander away. Especially in moments when your mind wanders. For example, when you are sitting in the tram or when you are sitting in the car waiting for the traffic lights. You can offer your immense love to all those who suffer. To all the miserable ones.

When you come home from work and you are still a bit fresh, you can do a little meditation. 10 minutes, 15 minutes. It is not necessary that it be in the evening... You should try to release everything that has accumulated during the day so that it comes and dissipates. The irritation, anxiety. And after that, you will have a good evening.

Okay. I am afraid to listen to my inner voice. That is the good voice that asks you, that tells you to meditate. At that moment, you should listen to it.

How to overcome fatigue when meditating for a long duration?

If it is fatigue, at that moment, you should open your eyes, put a bit more energy and stand up. At that

moment, you should take a very firm resolution not to be annihilated.

When you feel pain in the legs, for example, what should we do? Should we move?

First of all, you use it to understand the process of pain and suffering. These are two different things. First, you should use it to understand what pain and suffering are. Pain is normal for the body. Even the Buddha died very uncomfortably. Is that suffering? We suffer more through our relationship with pain. Suffering is something that we create. That is aversion, fear, rejection.

When pain arrives, aversion arises. You must very carefully observe the aversion and wait for it to disappear and return to the pain. When we return to the pain, the pain increases. Fear comes and we think that our foot is going to explode. The knee. And the foot. We note the fear and we return to the pain.

When fear and aversion disappear, when I can remain sitting in peace with the pain, at that moment, I am going to enter into the pain to discover the composition of the pain, how it is made. I will discover only pressure and heat, and when I note heat and pressure, the idea of pain disappears. Then I will realize that all this is created by the mind.

Now, if you cannot do this investigation because the pain is too great, then you can move.

But when you do this investigation, you are no longer meditating because you are trying to analyze it. No?

The question is that when you investigate pain, you are no longer meditating because you are analyzing it. We are not trying to establish an ideal mental state. That is another sort of meditation. When we do meditation on universal love, we create an ideal mental state, but in the framework of investigation, we analyze pain. And the fundamental question for the Buddha is why we suffer.

Just a quick follow-up question. So, when you feel the pain in your knee, and you feel that you are afraid of it or that you don't like it, does it manifest in another place in the body? It's probably not your knee. No. So my question is...

That is to say, at that moment, you move away from the pain and you return to the sensation of fear. We must find what fear is and who is afraid. Can we be with fear without fear? If we no longer have fear of fear, what will we be afraid of?

I believe it was President Roosevelt who said that the only thing we have to fear is fear itself. I think he was a Buddhist.

So, agreed? Then, at that moment, you should share all the merits that you accumulated today with all human beings.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

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*Kāraṇīyam-attha-kusalena yan-taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca
Sakko ujū ca sūjū ca suvaco c'assa mudu anatimānī

Santussako ca subharo ca appakicco ca sallahuka-vutti
Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesvananugiddho

Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ
Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā

Ye keci pāṇa-bhūtatthi tasā vā thāvarā vā anavasesā
Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakāṇuka-thūlā

Diṭṭhā vā yeva addiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre
Bhūtā vā sambhavesi vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā

Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kiñci
Byārosanā paṭigha-saññā nāññam-aññassa dukkham-iccheyya

Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttaṃ āyusā eka-puttam-anurakkhe
Evam-pi sabba-bhūtesu mānasam-bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ

Mettañ-ca sabba-lokasmi mānasam-bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyañ-ca asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ

Titṭhañ-caraṃ nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvatassa vitamiddho
Etaṃ satiraṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahmam-etaṃ vihāraṃ idham-āhu

Diṭṭhiñ-ca anupagamma sīlavā dassanena sampanno
Kāmesu vineya gedhaṃ na hi jātu gabbha-seyyaṃ punar-eti ti*

*Bhavatu sabba-maṅgalaṃ rakkhantu sabba-devatā
Sabba-buddhānu-bhāvena sadā sotthi bhavantu te
Bhavatu sabba-maṅgalaṃ rakkhantu sabba-devatā
Sabba-dhammānu-bhāvena sadā sotthi bhavantu te*

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